Perhaps the most controversial challenge to Modi's leadership came from Haren Pandya, the BJP strongman from Ahmedabad.

Pandya, like Modi, was strong-willed and charismatic. He was a two-time MLA and had been home minister in the Keshubhai Patel government when Modi became chief minister. Modi wanted Pandya to vacate his safe Ellisbridge seat in Ahmedabad for him. Pandya refused and a rather ugly battle ensued.

Pandya's own role during the riots was questionable—more than one account claims that he was among the mob leaders in the city. And yet, a few days after the riots, he dropped into our office in Ahmedabad with what sounded like a potential bombshell of a story. 'I have evidence that Modi allowed the riots to fester,' he claimed. On the night of 27 February, he said, Modi had called senior officials and told them to allow 'the public anger' to express itself. I asked him to come on record. He refused but gave me a document which showed that the Gujarat government was carrying out a survey to find out how the riots would politically influence the electorate.

What Pandya did not tell me on record, he told a Citizens' Tribunal headed by a retired judge in May that year. In August 2002, Pandya was removed from the government for breaching party discipline. In December, Modi ensured that Pandya was denied a ticket to contest the elections, even going to the extent of admitting himself to hospital to force the party leadership to agree to his demand. On 26 March 2003, while he was on his morning walk, Pandya was gunned down. The killers have not been caught till date, even as Pandya's family pointed a finger at Modi. A senior police officer told me, 'It was a contract killing, but who gave the contract we will never know.'

Remarkably, through all the chaos and controversy, Modi remained focused on his own political goals. He had won the battle within the BJP; he wanted to make an impact beyond. In this period between 2003 and 2007, Modi spent a considerable time understanding governance systems. Working a punishing eighteen-hour schedule at times, he was determined to chart a new path. He did not trust his fellow ministers, but he developed an implicit faith in the bureaucracy. Maybe he felt bureaucrats were less likely